

What are your current thoughts about Hong Kong?

The decision in Hong Kong to vote down the electoral reform package last year has caused Hong Kong residents to think seriously about the future of the territory. Perhaps this is an indication that the gap is closing between the mainland and Hong Kong despite a deadlock of political challenges.

How have recent ties been between China, Hong Kong and Taiwan?

Mounting challenges for China's President Xi Jinping on the South China Seas and continued tension amid the economic slowdown has not deterred China from closing its political and cultural grip on both Hong Kong and Taiwan. Last March, this was confirmed at the China People's Consultative Conference, one of the most senior political advisory bodies in the congress, and the National People's Congress – despite the recent demands from seniors within Hong Kong for an increasing degree of economy and democracy. If applicable, this will mean China will be balancing one country, three systems if Taiwan fails to continue recognizing China's 1992 consensus of One China. One can expect that Taiwan will drag its heels, whilst China may slow economic development and political communications with the new leadership of Taiwan. One may also presume that the mainland will tighten its grip on both Hong Kong and Taiwan this coming year.

What should we be expecting from China in the future?

China, I believe, will push forward towards closer cooperation with countries not only within ASEAN, but with the EU and almost all developing countries including Africa and America. For example, bilateral annual trade volume with the EU is expected to reach US\$1 trillion in a few years, but no later than 2020 which is a mutual goal.

Despite a slowdown this year, it seems manageable if China maintains a 6% to 7% GDP year-on-year. The same opportunities also apply in both central and eastern Europe.



The impact of the recent global financial crisis and the middle east migration of displaced refugees has created distractions but creates even more debt in the Eurozone, France, Greece, Spain and Turkey among others. These countries are being hit even more so with increasing labour strikes. Therefore Europe may delay China and the EU reaching its trade goals, particularly since the loss of labour overall has been rising in the EU for the last six years.

Another indication of China's rapidly rising role in global leadership is the AIIB (Asian Infrastructure Bank). Already half of all EU member states are founding members. Equally impressive is the recent agreement between the IMF and AIIB to consider joint process. Additional joint investment funds will follow to compliment the One Belt, One Road initiative which, with the Chinese mega project of infrastructure development, will certainly shroud the building of The Great Wall. Despite the global economic slowdown, China will continue to forge new partnerships and explore new opportunities regionally and globally.